Academic Amitabh Mattoo, a Kashmiri Pandit and an acknowledged expert on Kashmir, is surprised by the traction and attention that Vivek Agnihotri's recently released film *The Kashmir Files* is getting and regards it as unique. He was in Melbourne recently where the film was being screened before 200 Pandits living there. At the end of the movie, there was not a dry eye in the audience, with many weeping openly. Mattoo would have liked the film to have much more nuance on moderate Muslims who played a role in at least assuaging their suffering, but found the director had no interest in introducing grey in his black-and-white rendition of events or balance the narrative with any 'on the one hand' and 'on the other'. "For the audience," he says, "the film was a gut-wrenching experience that found deep resonance within the community that believes this is the closest any artistic venture has come to portray their suffering. It was an open demonstration of primordial emotion, purely from the victims' point of view, and they identified with it completely."

Back in India, where the film is running to full houses across the country, the response was even bigger. After an eyebrow-raising endorsement by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the film is likely to

A LITANY OF TROUBLES

The communal violence that led to the exodus of Kashmiri Pandits from the Valley had many causes—from violent insurgency and political miscalculations to malicious foreign actors and heavy-handed government reprisals



1975

With the signing of the 1975 Accord, also called the **Indira Gandhi-Sheikh Abdullah** accord, National Conference (NC) founder Sheikh Abdullah returns to power, agreeing to implement measures to further integrate the state with India. The main groups opposing the accord are the Jamaat-e-Islami and the People's League in J&K and the Jammu Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF) in Pakistan-controlled Kashmir

1978-1981

Sheikh Abdullah's government takes a confrontational stance against the Centre, deepening polarisation by Islamising the names of some 300 locations across the state. Pakistan's ISI steps up efforts to radicalise the Valley's Muslims by spreading militant Wahabism in place of Sufism

1982

Sheikh Abdullah dies. His son Farooq succeeds him as chief minister

1984

The execution of JKLF militant Maqbool Bhat in February triggers widespread protests in the Valley, which are crushed by the Indian army. In July, with the support of PM Indira Gandhi, Farooq's brother-in-law Ghulam Mohammed Shah becomes chief minister. In October, Prime Minister Gandhi is assassinated by her Sikh bodyguards, and anti-Sikh riots break out in Delhi